Ashoka's presence came to be invoked that are not specifically associated with the emperor during his lifetime. The kingdom of Kashmir is an example of this. It is described by Xuanzang in ways that strike a resonance with anyone who has visited it—surrounded by high mountains, with a 'cold and stern' climate, people 'handsome in appearance' who loved learning and were 'well instructed'.[42] It also happened to be a region which had its own history, and from this the pilgrim quotes to give Ashoka's connection with the kingdom. Ashoka is said to have built four stupas there. The Chinese visitor believes 'each of these has about a pint measure of relics of the Tathagata.'[43] Ashoka is described as a king of Magadha who 'extended his power over the world, and was honoured even by the most distant people. He deeply reverenced the three gems, and had a loving regard for all living beings.'[44] Of the priests whom the king honoured, though, was a group that became schismatic, and this group Ashoka intended to drown in the Ganga. They, 'having seen the danger threatening their lives, by exercise of their spiritual power flew away', and arriving in Kashmir concealed themselves.[45] When Ashoka-raja heard of this he repented and begged them to return. They refused. Consequently, as atonement, he built 500 monasteries for them in Kashmir.

These vignettes are revealing. It seems that in Kashmir, if Xuanzang is to be believed, there was a strong tradition linking Ashoka with the valley. Within this tradition the emperor was recognized in his political persona—as ruling a large empire; and in his religious role—as the builder of stupas and monasteries. Some five hundred years later Ashoka was again invoked, now in Kashmir's twelfth-century chronicle, the *Rajatarangini* of Kalhana. A learned Sanskrit poet, Kalhana had put together this chronicle replete with historical detail, causing it to be described by its modern translator, M.A. Stein, as a text that came 'nearest in character to the Chronicles of Mediaeval Europe and of the Muhammad[an] East.'[46] Regarding the possibility that the Chinese pilgrim used an early history of Kashmir, Stein